Episode 2

The Whispering Pagoda

វត្តខ្សឹបខ្សៀវ

Game Design and Narrative Specification

Setting	Village pagoda and scripture library, Battambang Province
In-story time	Night of Pchum Ben · 11:45 PM – 4:00 AM
Playtime	3 – 4 hours
Seal	#2 · The Silver Betel Box
Version	2.0 · October 2026 · Draft for review

Contents

01 Episode Overview

02 Characters

03 Locations and Layout

04 Story and Gameplay by Act

- Act I · The Gates of Pchum Ben
- Act II · The Wandering Shadows
- Act III · The Scripture Archive and Seal #2
- Resolution and Cliffhanger

05 Mechanics Reference

06 Puzzle Walkthroughs

07 Entities

08 Items and Collectibles

09 Audio and Visual Specification

10 Glossary

11 Revision Notes and Open Issues

01 Episode Overview

On Pchum Ben, the night the gates between the living and the dead stand open, Sora follows the blood on her map to the village pagoda. Blind hungry ghosts hunt by sound among the ancestral stupas, and the only way to the scripture library holding her family's record is through them.

LOCATION	NIGHT	PLAYTIME
Village pagoda	**Pchum Ben**	**3 – 4 hours**
Stupa garden and scripture library	Festival of the Dead	3 acts

CORE MECHANIC	ENTITIES	SEAL
Sound-based stealth	**Pret · Neak Ta shadow**	**#2 Silver Betel Box**
Noise, line of sight, lamp shutter	Blind hunters · perimeter stalker	The 1910 offering

1.1 Episode goal

Reach the locked scripture library in the middle of the lotus pond, recover the family's palm-leaf record and the **Silver Betel Box** (Seal #2), and escape the pagoda before the 4:00 AM bell.

1.2 Role in the series

Introduces	Crouching, surface-based footstep noise, holding breath, the lamp shutter, thrown distractions, the mirror light-beam puzzle and the timed escape.
Reveals	A vision of the 1910 pact: Sora's great-grandfather offering the family's silver betel box to a spirit to save his family from starvation.
Leads to	A 1925 photograph of Uncle Sok at a floating clinic on the Tonle Sap, the setting of Episode 3.

1.3 Visual identity

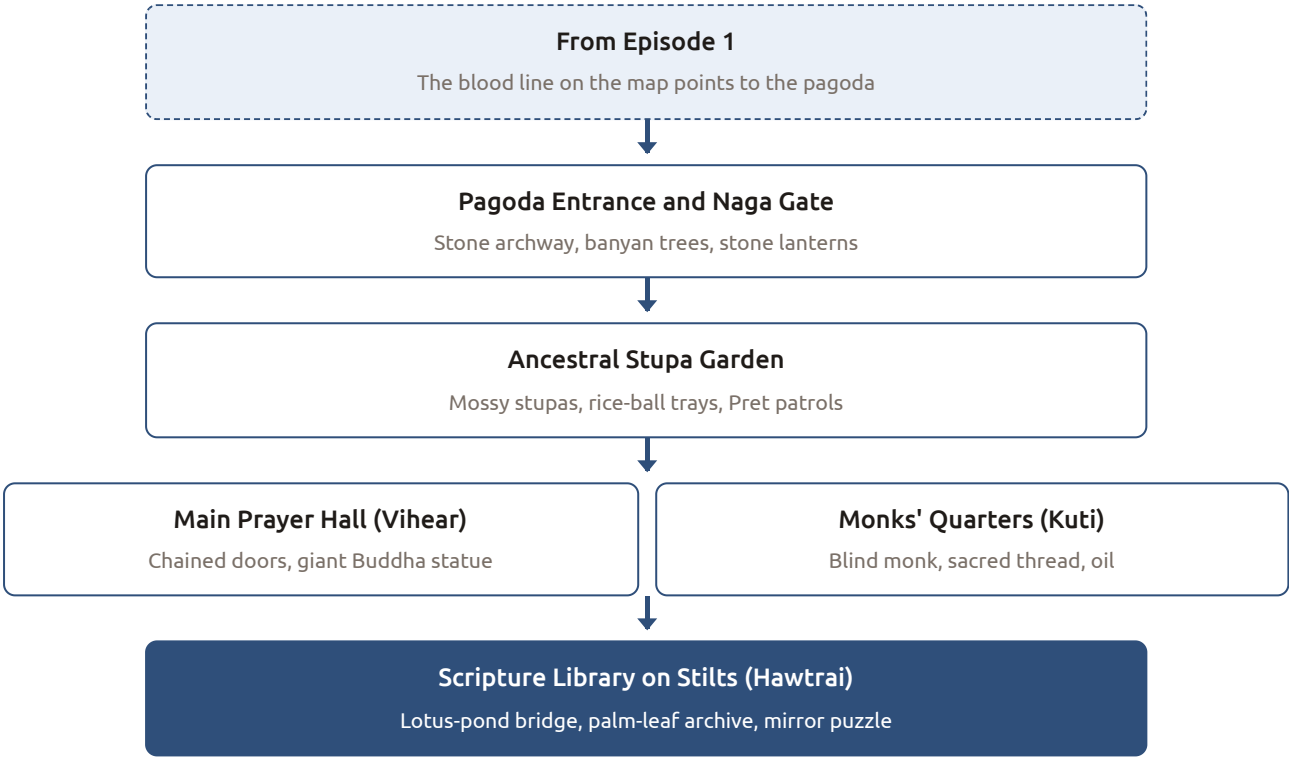
Cold moonlight blue, mossy grey stone, flickering lotus oil cups, fog drifting over the lily ponds and pitch-black shadows between the stupas.

02 Characters

Character	Role	Description	Gameplay function
Sora ស៊ូរ៉ា	Protagonist	Exhausted from the night at the stilt house. She uses her artist's eye to read sacred Pali-Khmer scripts and to map routes between the stupas.	Player character.
Venerable Sophal ព្រះតេជគុណ សុផល 82, head monk	Mentor	An old, blind head monk living in the quiet monks' quarters. He gives cryptic warnings about Uncle Sok's past and explains how to survive the night of Pchum Ben.	Tutorial and rules of the night; gives the protective thread.
The Pret ប្រេត	Enemies	Hungry ghosts 3–4 metres tall, with needle-thin necks, hollow glowing eyes and swollen stomachs. They roam the stupa yard searching for rice offerings.	Blind, sound-hunting patrol enemies.
The Neak Ta shadow អ្នកតា	Antagonist	The entity from Episode 1, now stalking the pagoda's edges and trying to destroy the manuscript before Sora can read it.	Scripted pressure; drives the escape.

03 Locations and Layout

3.1 Progression map



3.2 Area details

Area	Description and key props	Lighting	Gameplay use
Entrance and Naga Gate	A crumbling 19th-century stone archway flanked by moss-covered multi-headed Naga (ឆាគ) serpents. Fallen banyan leaves, stone lanterns with burnt-out wicks, an old iron bell on a wooden beam.	Moonlight, mist	Arrival; sets the mood
Ancestral Stupa Garden ចេតិយ	More than fifty carved stone ash monuments, 1–4 metres tall, forming a maze of narrow dirt paths. Burnt incense, lotus bowls, woven bamboo trays of sticky rice balls (បាយបិណ្ឌ), Sanskrit inscriptions on lichen-covered stone.	Pale blue moonlight through banyan branches; deep shadows between stupas	Stealth maze; offering puzzle

Area	Description and key props	Lighting	Gameplay use
Main Prayer Hall វិហារ	A high-roofed brick hall with multi-tiered red tiles and carved wooden pillars. The main doors are padlocked with heavy iron chains; through the windows, a towering golden Buddha sits in shadow.	Dim candlelight inside	Landmark; inaccessible (atmosphere)
Monks' Quarters កុដិ	Modest wooden huts where the monks live.	Warm oil lamps	Safe area; meeting the monk; supplies
Scripture Library ហោរ៉ាត្រែ	A 100-year-old carved teak building on tall stilts in the middle of a dark lotus pond, reached only by a narrow plank bridge. Hundreds of palm-leaf manuscripts (ស្លឹករឹត) in carved lacquer cabinets, brass oil braziers, and polished bronze mirrors on swivelling wooden stands.	Moonlight through a roof window; braziers	Mirror puzzle; flashback; escape

04 Story and Gameplay by Act

Act I · The Gates of Pchum Ben

Playtime 0:00 – 1:00 · Story 11:45 PM – 12:30 AM

NARRATIVE

Sora arrives at the village pagoda on a creaking bicycle at **11:45 PM**. It is the height of Pchum Ben (ភ្ជុំបិណ្ឌ), the night the gates between the spirit world and the human world open. The grounds are deathly quiet under a low mist.

In the monks' quarters she meets Venerable Sophal, the blind head monk. He tells her that Uncle Sok came to the pagoda a year ago to study forbidden spirit-binding texts. To break the second seal, Sora must retrieve her family's palm-leaf manuscript from the locked scripture library over the lotus pond. He gives her a blessed white cotton thread for protection and a warning:

> *"Tonight, the hungry spirits walk among the ash stupas. They have no sight, but they hear every breath. Do not step into their path, and do not waste the rice offerings."*
>
> Venerable Sophal

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Crouching and stealth	Crouch behind stupas; footsteps are louder on dry leaves than on soft dirt; hold breath when an entity passes close.
Lamp shutter	The hurricane lamp's metal shutter now closes, hiding the light instantly without putting out the flame.
Rules of the night	The monk's warning is recorded in the sketchbook as the episode's taboos.

Act II · The Wandering Shadows

Playtime 1:00 – 2:30 · Story 12:30 – 2:30 AM

NARRATIVE

In the stupa garden, tall, gaunt Pret patrol the paths, drawn by the scent of funeral offerings. The gate to the lotus-pond bridge is sealed with a bronze lock bearing four symbols.

To open it, Sora must find the four stupas that belong to her family line, marked with the family emblem drawn in her sketchbook, and place the correct offering in front of each: sticky rice balls, lotus buds or sanctified water. All the while, she must avoid the Pret.

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Spatial audio stealth	Pret give off raspy, high-pitched breathing. Players track them around stone corners by 3D sound.
Offering puzzle	Clues from Uncle Sok's journal and the family inscriptions tell which offering belongs at which ancestor's stupa (see section 6.1).
Distractions	Sora can throw small clay rice bowls to make noise and lure Pret away from narrow passages.

Act III · The Scripture Archive and Seal #2

Playtime 2:30 – 3:30 · Story 2:30 – 4:00 AM

NARRATIVE

With the gate open, Sora crosses the rickety bridge to the library. Among shelves of palm-leaf manuscripts she finds her family's record box.

Opening the cabinet triggers an interactive **flashback**: in 1910, her great-grandfather kneels before an ancient stone altar and offers a sacred family relic, a **silver betel box**, to a woodland spirit in exchange for saving his family from starvation.

The vision shatters as the Neak Ta shadow slams against the library's wooden walls, and the whole building groans on its stilts over the pond.

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Moonlight mirror puzzle	Rotate the polished bronze mirrors to bounce a beam of moonlight from the roof window onto the silver lock of the central cabinet (see section 6.2).
Seal #2	The cabinet holds the Silver Betel Box, engraved with ancient guardian runes.
Escape sequence	The entity breaks through the roof beams and the shelves collapse. Sora must cross the collapsing bridge on a timer while shadow tendrils reach out of the water.

Resolution and Cliffhanger

Story 4:00 AM

Sora reaches the safety of the main archway as the first bell of **4:00 AM** rings, driving the Pret and the shadow back into the darkness.

Inside the Silver Betel Box she finds a dried, pressed water-lily leaf wrapped around a photograph from 1925. It shows Uncle Sok standing on a floating wooden clinic on the Tonle Sap lake. A fresh line of blood seeps from the photograph's edges, pointing to **Episode 3: The Drowned Village**.

05 Mechanics Reference

New mechanics in this episode. Everything from Episode 1 still applies. Values marked *target* are starting points for playtesting.

Mechanic	Rules	Feedback to the player
Crouch	Lowers the camera, slows movement and roughly halves footstep noise (*target*). Stupas block line of sight and sound.	Lower view; softer footsteps.
Surface noise	Each ground surface has a noise level: dry leaves are loud, stone is medium, soft dirt and moss are quiet.	Distinct footstep sounds per surface.
Hold breath	Silences Sora's breathing for a few seconds (*target* 6 s), then a recovery gasp that is loud if she holds too long.	Muffled sound; heartbeat; gasp.
Lamp shutter	Three lamp states: open, shuttered (flame still burning and still using oil, no light) and out. Shuttering is instant; relighting costs a match.	Shutter position visible on the lamp model.
Distraction	Thrown clay rice bowls make a noise where they land. Pret investigate the sound. A limited number are available.	Smash sound; Pret turn toward it.
Rice-offering taboo	Wasting or knocking over rice offerings counts as a broken taboo and attracts nearby Pret.	Pret shriek; noted in the sketchbook.

06 Puzzle Walkthroughs

6.1 The stupa offerings

Step	Action	Result
1	Compare the family emblem in the sketchbook with the carvings on the stupas.	Four family stupas identified and sketched on the map.
2	Read the inscriptions and Uncle Sok's notes to learn each ancestor's name and the offering that suits them.	An offering list forms in the sketchbook.
3	Collect offerings: rice balls from the trays, lotus buds from the pond's edge, sanctified water from the monks' quarters.	Offerings in the satchel.
4	Place the correct offering at each stupa while avoiding the Pret.	Each correct offering lights one symbol on the bronze gate lock.
5	With all four symbols lit, the gate opens.	Access to the lotus-pond bridge.

6.2 The moonlight mirrors

Step	Action	Result
1	Find the beam of moonlight entering through the roof window.	Starting point of the puzzle.
2	Rotate each bronze mirror on its stand to pass the beam from mirror to mirror.	The beam travels across the room.
3	Direct the final reflection onto the silver lock of the central cabinet.	The cabinet opens: family record and Silver Betel Box.

07 Entities

Entity	Senses	Behaviour	How to survive
Pret ប្រេត	Hearing only (blind)	Patrol set paths through the stupa garden. Investigate noises and are drawn to rice offerings. Catch Sora if they touch her or hear her up close.	Crouch, walk on soft ground, hold breath, throw bowls, stay out of their path.
Neak Ta shadow	Scripted	Circles the pagoda's edges; attacks the library in Act III; reaches from the water during the escape.	Keep moving during the escape; follow the safe route.

08 Items and Collectibles

Item	Type	Found / use
Blessed white cotton thread	Key item	Given by Venerable Sophal. Protection; used again in Episode 5.
Clay rice bowls	Consumable	Stupa garden. Thrown as distractions.
Rice balls, lotus buds, sanctified water	Puzzle items	Garden trays, pond edge, monks' quarters. Offerings.
Oil and matches	Consumable	Monks' quarters and lanterns.
Family palm-leaf record	Story item	Library cabinet. Triggers the 1910 flashback.
Silver Betel Box	Seal #2	Library cabinet.
1925 photograph and water-lily leaf	Story item	Inside the betel box. Points to Episode 3.

09 Audio and Visual Specification

Colour palette	Pale moonlight blue, mossy green stone, deep navy, cold silver, warm lotus-candle gold.
Post-processing	Fog over water, dynamic shadows cast by the stupas, bloom on moonlight beams, film grain.
Light sources	Shuttered hurricane lamp, pale moonlight, glowing lotus oil cups, reflected light from bronze mirrors.
Ambience	Soft wind chimes, frogs in the lotus pond, rustling dry leaves, distant temple bells.
Horror sound cues	High-pitched raspy Pret shrieks, heavy creaking beams, splashes in the water, whispered chanting.
Interface	100% diegetic. Inventory and puzzle clues in the sketchbook; shutter position visible on the lamp.

10 Glossary

Term (v1)	Khmer	Meaning	Note
Pchum Ben	ភ្ជុំបិណ្ឌ	Festival of the Dead	
Bay Ben	បាយបិណ្ឌ	Rice-ball offerings for the dead	
Pret	ប្រេត	Hungry ghost	
Wat	វត្ត	Pagoda / monastery	
Chedi	ចេតិយ	Stupa holding ashes	
Vihear	វិហារ	Main prayer hall	
Kuti	កុដិ	Monk's living quarters	
Hawtrai	ហោរ៉ែត្រ	Scripture library	
Naga	នាគ	Mythical serpent guardian	
Hup Mak	ប្រអប់ស្ពា	Betel box	v1 term unclear; confirm

All Khmer spellings, including character names and titles, should be confirmed by a native speaker and cultural advisor.

11 Revision Notes and Open Issues

Changes from v1.0

- Reorganised into the standard episode structure; added mechanics, puzzle, entity, item and glossary sections.
- Added story-clock times to every act.
- Khmer text now renders correctly.

Open issues

DECIDE BEFORE BUILDING EPISODE 2

- **No counter-ritual for the Silver Betel Box.** Episodes 1, 3 and 4 each end by burning, purifying or melting their seal, but this episode only retrieves it. Episode 5 treats all four seals as destroyed and needs a "Silver Betel Box inlay". Suggestion: a short dawn ritual at the family stupa that releases the inlay.
- **The flashback and Episode 4 must agree** on where and how the 1910 pact was made (forest altar vs. rubber estate contract).
- **Gap between episodes:** make clear that this is the following night.
- **Pchum Ben timing:** the festival lasts 15 days; decide which night this is (the final day, Pchum Ben itself, is the natural choice).
- **Monk's title:** confirm the correct Khmer form of address for a head monk.